

# whatweretheythinking.com

www.thebeerbelly.com

When we came across thebeerbelly.com, it took us several minutes to shake our heads and finally acknowledge that the site did sell, on order, a strap-on body sac within which a beverage pouch could be hidden. Its not the ludricrity of the object on sale that stunned us—the Internet is a notorious hub for sales of all kinds—what amazed us is that there have been

people who have actually already bought the thing and think its cool! If the claims of the site are to be believed, beer bellies are in fashion.

There are accessories for the beer belly on offer as well. There's the ice pack "pleasure extender," to keep your drink hot or cold depending on what the beverage is—and a cleanser and brushes to clean out the

pouch. Talk about a full deal! And then we have the ever-gracious buyers and visitors, who have kept up the spirit of the whole thing with plenty of community blog posts. The site even offers instructions with their very own Tips & Tricks on how to use the Beer Belly. What were the parties on both sides thinking?

We all agree that the site is humorous, but the site forgets to mention an important detail: what would people who already posses a beer belly do with a contraption that will make them look doubly rotund? The blessing in disguise that we spot in the whole idea is that the desire for a such a thing might actually convince some of the pot-bellied to try and get rid of the original—so they can sport one of these!



A pouch to augment your paunch!

The survey results are surprising. Why isn't the number higher than that 20 per cent average? After all, who goes to libraries any more? They all have access to the Internet, and then, of course, there's Wikipedia. You can't blame the kids, really. It's all there, and why do serious research when you can lift stuff off a page?

The answer is online research. Kids can actually do *research* on the Internet, while validating the information they garner. They can then perform a critical analysis of what they've found, and use *that* for their assignments—just as if they'd been to a library.

Talking about plagiarism, Wikipedia is in the news again: founder Jimmy Wales has asked that college students refrain from citing Wikipedia as a source of research. Some students are complaining to *him* when teachers fail them for citing the user-edited encyclopaedia! Wales reportedly receives 10 complaint mails a week from

college students, saying they flunked because of his site!

Wikipedia is considering putting up a fact sheet on the site. It would explain why it's not a definitive source of information, and teachers could hand it out, Wales said. Actually, it should be obvious: how can something that's edited by users be cited?

But still, with Wikipedia and other online sources providing so much well-formatted information for free, we think plagiarism—or at least online "research"—can only increase. There's something wrong going on here. Consider this: (a) The information and analysis is out there; (b) Assignments demand that students collate and analyse the same information; and (c) There's no stopping the growth of info on the Web.

Why, therefore, don't schools and universities accept that the times they are a-changin', and revise their grading methods? It's a problem of an old system caught up in an age it wasn't prepared for. ■

## Blog WATCH

Everyone's talking about Vista, Google, and Microsoft. (As always.) Here's something about the Gates-stepping-down thing. Also, a negative rant about Vista, and two Google-related posts. Lots of links and comments at these blogs!

Guest Columnist

<http://snipurl.com/blogjul1>

([www.thoughtmechanics.com/2006/06/20/retirement-of-bill-gates-from-microsoft-is-no-big-deal/](http://www.thoughtmechanics.com/2006/06/20/retirement-of-bill-gates-from-microsoft-is-no-big-deal/))

### Retirement of Gates from MS Is No Big Deal

People seem to be making a big deal about the announcement that Bill Gates will be retiring from active involvement in Microsoft...

His retirement may be delayed by CEOs of other companies trying to retire. They may complain that Gates has an unfair monopoly on retirement. At this point the Justice Department may have to get involved to analyze the impact of his retirement on the CEOs of other companies...

Robert Accettura

<http://snipurl.com/blogjul3>

(<http://robert.accettura.com/archives/2006/06/09/windows-vista/>)

### Windows Vista

Am I the only one who is not very impressed with Windows Vista? Several things so far have just shown to be a complete turnoff.

It warns me about everything. Warnings stink, people just ignore them if they happen to often...

Learning Curves are evil. The new Save dialog isn't totally evil, but it's quasi evil. It took me a few seconds to figure out how it works, and still feels really really awkward no matter what method I use to navigate...

Despite my best effort, I'm still not sure why I'm denied permission to my Application Data directory...

Joel Walsh

<http://snipurl.com/blogjul4>

([www.sourcearticles.net/computer-articles/googles-good-writing-content-filter.html](http://www.sourcearticles.net/computer-articles/googles-good-writing-content-filter.html))

### Google's Good Writing Content Filter

The web pages actually at the top of Google have only one thing clearly in common: good writing. Don't let the usual SEO sacred cows and bugbears, such as PageRank, frames, and JavaScript, distract you from the importance of good content.

I was recently struck by the fact that the top-ranking web pages on Google are consistently much better written than the vast majority of what one reads on the web. Yet traditional SEO wisdom has little to say about good writing. Does Google really only display web pages that meet arcane technical criteria? Apparently not. Google is doing a good job of identifying websites with good content and rewarding them with high rankings...

sophistry

<http://sophistry.org/blog/?p=13>

### The nonexistent Google-Microsoft rivalry

Google's newest products seem to be challenging the Office suite. This makes it easy to write articles about a Microsoft-Google rivalry. But it's also wrong... Google's business is ads. Microsoft's is software. If Google's apps make a dent in Microsoft, it will be incidental to their real goal, which is improving your search results. The key to Google's plan is getting as much of your data online as possible, search it and have their technology determine what ads best match your growing profile...